to the *New York Times* and *Gulf News* on the way to Sriperumbudur. The SIT had collected the cassettes from Ramamurthy at the beginning of the investigation. The crime branch of Madras Police had taken the cassette from Maragatham Chandrasekar's videographer. The head office of the IB from Delhi had sought the cassettes on the pretext of making a presentation to the PMO. But neither of the cassettes had been returned to the SIT.

Anirudhya had spoken to Kaarthikeyan about the cassettes. His candid reply was, 'The videotape was hazy.' Apparently, it was not going to add any value to the SIT's probe. According to him, shortly before the blast, Dhanu, along with photographer Haribabu, had been seen talking to Latha Kannan. One man, probably a party worker, presented a shawl to Rajiv Gandhi and then posed for a photograph, all the while holding him with both arms. Rajiv Gandhi was struggling to move through the crowd of admirers. The videographers were shooting from the stage, which was not very close to where Rajiv was standing. It was a makeshift stage and had only one source of power for the cameramen. Even as Rajiv Gandhi got closer to the stage, the crowd swelled. They hovered around the videographers, who had no choice but to disconnect from the power source and switch off their cameras.

Going by what Kaarthikeyan told Anirudhya, the contents of the video cassettes were of no value. Why would the IB sit on them, then? After a series of phone calls, director of the IB, M.K. Narayanan, granted Anirudhya audience at the India International Centre in New Delhi. Rushing to the city for just one meeting and then going back to Madras by air was difficult for Anirudhya to explain to the bosses at *India Today*. The Madras office could not book his flight for want of approval from the Delhi office. As luck would have it, Narayanan was to visit Madras. Anirudhya caught up with him at the Trident hotel two days later.

The IB chief was clear. However, it was not possible to establish whether the woman made her way into the sterilized area only after Rajiv Gandhi arrived or if she had been waiting there as one of the guests whose names were cleared by the authorities to greet him. Video recordings of this part of the meeting were being scanned to identify the woman, he said. This